with Ratan and some even touched his feet. There was almost a ‘mini stampede’ around him. On the occasion, Ratan was a ‘charmer, all smiles’, Sinha adds.

The Government of India has recognized Ratan with the Padma Bhushan and Padma Vibhushan, the third- and second-highest civilian awards in the country respectively. Social media groups have long campaigned for the highest civilian award, the Bharat Ratna, to be conferred on him.

Perhaps, what Saul P. Steinberg said about Jean Riboud, a strong influence on Ratan, that ‘[he] impersonates a businessman who is trying to hide a certain poetry’, is more apt for the latter.

Universal Recognition

Ratan has earned extraordinary respect and the admiration of leaders, both political and industrial, across the globe. Greenberg says, ‘I haven’t met anybody who didn’t admire him.’ What has been most significant perhaps is Ratan’s close association with several of the world’s important leaders and bodies.

With him as the face of the group, the Tatas gained greater recognition and credibility, Chandrasekaran opines. But it was not only the group that benefitted from it, the nation also did. His friendship with Henry Kissinger, hidden from public view, is also said to have influenced the thawing of the frosty bilateral relations between India and the US after the 1971 Bangladesh crisis.

Ratan recalls that he had persuaded Kissinger to visit India after the bilateral relations had hit their nadir during the crisis. Ratan had nudged Kissinger who continued as US secretary of state under President Gerald Ford, to mend the relationship between the two nations.

The visit that fructified in October 1974, was noteworthy for the reconciliatory tone that the secretary of state struck. In the speech he delivered in the Indian Council on World Affairs in New Delhi, he said: ‘We can build our relations free of past distortions and conscious of the interests and values we share.’ Commenting that the speech was ‘basically conciliatory’, *The New York Times* added that an agreement that was signed by the two sides was ‘a concrete expression of the desire’ of the ‘two Governments to build up an institutional framework for meaningful cooperation’. The visit even made Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, an